They discovered two terrorists holed up in a hideout in one of the villages and on being interrogated they told us that there were about ten of them hiding in different places. So the search was intensified. I was addressing the menfolk who had been asked to congregate in the school compound, when a police inspector whispered to me that a serious development had occurred in an adjacent area, and that it needed my attention urgently.

On reaching the spot indicated by the inspector, I saw a bizarre scene. In an open ground there was the second-in-command of 8 Bihar flanked by two terrorists with AK-47s slung on their shoulders and a grenade each in their hands. While we had cordoned off the entire area, Lieutenant Colonel Harjit Singh was taken hostage right in the middle of the village by two fanatics who were ready to commit mayhem and were prepared to die. They conveyed that they would like to negotiate with none other than the brigade commander. They were tall, smart and a bit cocky in their attitude. But I must admit that I was impressed by the cool approach of Harjit Singh. If anyone had panicked, the outcome could have been catastrophic. Standing out of grenade-throwing range, about 50 metres away behind a hedge, I conveyed to them through Captain Shakeel Ahmad, a brave officer of the battalion, that their entire gang had been caught but in case they let go of the officer, they would not be harmed. They asked for some water and a bottle of water was placed near them. Both of them surveyed the deployment of troops all around them and must have realized that there was no way they could escape.

In the meanwhile Lieutenant Colonel Harjit Singh somehow broke away from their clutches and joined us.

The terrorists spoke to each other and all of a sudden lobbed the grenades in my direction and opened fire with their Kalashnikovs. We dived and hit the ground. The grenade splinters flew all around us and bullets whizzed past overhead. Fortunately, the brunt of the attack was taken by the embankment in front of us. Our faces and bodies were splattered with the melting snow and mud which flew in all directions when the grenades burst. I had a feeling that I had been hit by splinters but luckily it was only muck formed by the